

SOCIAL ANXIETY WORKBOOK

Face Your Fears & Build Confidence

CBT-Based Exercises Including:

Thought Challenging | Behavioral Experiments
Exposure Hierarchy | Assertiveness Training

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SOCIAL ANXIETY WORKBOOK

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WHAT IS SOCIAL ANXIETY?

Social Anxiety Disorder (SAD) is more than shyness. It's an intense fear of:

- Being judged or evaluated negatively by others
- Embarrassing or humiliating yourself
- Being the center of attention
- Saying something 'stupid'
- Others noticing you're anxious
- Everyday situations like ordering food or making phone calls

The Social Anxiety Cycle:

1. Anticipatory anxiety (worrying before the event)
2. Safety behaviors (avoiding eye contact, rehearsing, staying quiet)
3. Self-focused attention (monitoring how you look/sound)
4. Post-event processing (replaying and criticizing yourself after)
5. Avoidance (canceling plans, saying no, isolating)

SAFETY BEHAVIORS IDENTIFICATION

Safety behaviors MAINTAIN social anxiety by preventing you from learning that your fears won't come true. Check all that apply to you:

- ☐ Avoiding eye contact
- ☐ Speaking very quietly
- ☐ Rehearsing what to say
- ☐ Holding a drink to hide trembling hands
- ☐ Wearing certain clothes to avoid sweating
- ☐ Arriving early/late to avoid mingling
- ☐ Staying near exits
- ☐ Only speaking when spoken to
- ☐ Over-preparing for conversations
- ☐ Using alcohol to cope socially
- ☐ Checking phone to look busy
- ☐ Deflecting attention/compliments
- ☐ Standing at edges of groups

My other safety behaviors: _____

COGNITIVE DISTORTIONS IN SOCIAL SITUATIONS

MIND READING:

Assuming you know what others think about you.

Example: 'They think I'm boring' (without evidence)

FORTUNE TELLING:

Predicting negative outcomes before they happen.

Example: 'I'll definitely embarrass myself at the party'

SPOTLIGHT EFFECT:

Believing everyone notices your anxiety.

Example: 'Everyone can see I'm blushing/sweating'

CATASTROPHIZING:

Blowing consequences out of proportion.

Example: 'If I say something wrong, everyone will hate me'

DISQUALIFYING THE POSITIVE:

Dismissing positive social experiences.

Example: 'They were just being polite, they don't really like me'

EMOTIONAL REASONING:

Feeling anxious = something IS wrong.

Example: 'I feel awkward so I must BE awkward'

THOUGHT CHALLENGING WORKSHEET (1/6)

Social Situation: _____

Anxious Thought: _____

Distortion Type (circle): Mind Reading / Fortune Telling / Spotlight /
Catastrophizing / Disqualifying Positive / Emotional Reasoning

Evidence this thought is TRUE:

Evidence this thought is NOT true:

What would I tell a friend with this thought? _____

Balanced/realistic thought: _____

Belief in anxious thought: Before ____% After ____%

Anxiety level: Before ____ (0-10) After ____ (0-10)

THOUGHT CHALLENGING WORKSHEET (2/6)

Social Situation: _____

Anxious Thought: _____

Distortion Type (circle): Mind Reading / Fortune Telling / Spotlight /
Catastrophizing / Disqualifying Positive / Emotional Reasoning

Evidence this thought is TRUE:

Evidence this thought is NOT true:

What would I tell a friend with this thought? _____

Balanced/realistic thought: _____

Belief in anxious thought: Before ____% After ____%

Anxiety level: Before ____ (0-10) After ____ (0-10)

THOUGHT CHALLENGING WORKSHEET (3/6)

Social Situation: _____

Anxious Thought: _____

Distortion Type (circle): Mind Reading / Fortune Telling / Spotlight /
Catastrophizing / Disqualifying Positive / Emotional Reasoning

Evidence this thought is TRUE:

Evidence this thought is NOT true:

What would I tell a friend with this thought? _____

Balanced/realistic thought: _____

Belief in anxious thought: Before ____% After ____%

Anxiety level: Before ____ (0-10) After ____ (0-10)

THOUGHT CHALLENGING WORKSHEET (4/6)

Social Situation: _____

Anxious Thought: _____

Distortion Type (circle): Mind Reading / Fortune Telling / Spotlight /
Catastrophizing / Disqualifying Positive / Emotional Reasoning

Evidence this thought is TRUE:

Evidence this thought is NOT true:

What would I tell a friend with this thought? _____

Balanced/realistic thought: _____

Belief in anxious thought: Before ____% After ____%

Anxiety level: Before ____ (0-10) After ____ (0-10)

THOUGHT CHALLENGING WORKSHEET (5/6)

Social Situation: _____

Anxious Thought: _____

Distortion Type (circle): Mind Reading / Fortune Telling / Spotlight /
Catastrophizing / Disqualifying Positive / Emotional Reasoning

Evidence this thought is TRUE:

Evidence this thought is NOT true:

What would I tell a friend with this thought? _____

Balanced/realistic thought: _____

Belief in anxious thought: Before ____% After ____%

Anxiety level: Before ____ (0-10) After ____ (0-10)

THOUGHT CHALLENGING WORKSHEET (6/6)

Social Situation: _____

Anxious Thought: _____

Distortion Type (circle): Mind Reading / Fortune Telling / Spotlight /
Catastrophizing / Disqualifying Positive / Emotional Reasoning

Evidence this thought is TRUE:

Evidence this thought is NOT true:

What would I tell a friend with this thought? _____

Balanced/realistic thought: _____

Belief in anxious thought: Before ____% After ____%

Anxiety level: Before ____ (0-10) After ____ (0-10)

BEHAVIORAL EXPERIMENT (1/5)

My prediction (what I think will happen): _____

Belief in prediction (0-100%): ____

The experiment (what I will do to test it): _____

Safety behaviors I will DROP during the experiment:

ACTUAL OUTCOME (what really happened): _____

Was my prediction accurate? _____

What I learned: _____

Updated belief in prediction (0-100%): ____

BEHAVIORAL EXPERIMENT (2/5)

My prediction (what I think will happen): _____

Belief in prediction (0-100%): ____

The experiment (what I will do to test it): _____

Safety behaviors I will DROP during the experiment:

ACTUAL OUTCOME (what really happened): _____

Was my prediction accurate? _____

What I learned: _____

Updated belief in prediction (0-100%): ____

BEHAVIORAL EXPERIMENT (3/5)

My prediction (what I think will happen): _____

Belief in prediction (0-100%): ____

The experiment (what I will do to test it): _____

Safety behaviors I will DROP during the experiment:

ACTUAL OUTCOME (what really happened): _____

Was my prediction accurate? _____

What I learned: _____

Updated belief in prediction (0-100%): ____

BEHAVIORAL EXPERIMENT (4/5)

My prediction (what I think will happen): _____

Belief in prediction (0-100%): ____

The experiment (what I will do to test it): _____

Safety behaviors I will DROP during the experiment:

ACTUAL OUTCOME (what really happened): _____

Was my prediction accurate? _____

What I learned: _____

Updated belief in prediction (0-100%): ____

BEHAVIORAL EXPERIMENT (5/5)

My prediction (what I think will happen): _____

Belief in prediction (0-100%): ____

The experiment (what I will do to test it): _____

Safety behaviors I will DROP during the experiment:

ACTUAL OUTCOME (what really happened): _____

Was my prediction accurate? _____

What I learned: _____

Updated belief in prediction (0-100%): ____

EXPOSURE HIERARCHY FOR SOCIAL SITUATIONS

List social situations from least to most anxiety-provoking:

[10] _____

[20] _____

[30] _____

[40] _____

[50] _____

[60] _____

[70] _____

[80] _____

[90] _____

[100] _____

Start at the bottom. Practice each until anxiety drops 50%.

Post-event processing (PEP) = replaying social situations in your mind, focusing on everything you did 'wrong.' This MAINTAINS social anxiety.

1. NOTICE: 'I'm doing post-event processing right now.'
2. REDIRECT: Shift attention to present moment (5 senses).
3. REMIND: 'My anxious brain exaggerates. The reality was probably fine.'
4. STOP: Set a rule - no analyzing social events after they're over.

[illegible]

ATTENTION TRAINING EXERCISES

Social anxiety makes you SELF-FOCUSED. The cure: shift to EXTERNAL focus.

Exercise 1: The Observer

In a social situation, focus entirely on the OTHER person. Notice their eye color, what they're wearing, their tone. You can't be self-conscious if all your attention is on them.

Exercise 2: The Reporter

Pretend you're a journalist. Your job is to find out 3 interesting things about each person you talk to. Ask questions. Listen to answers.

Exercise 3: The Noticer

In a group, notice 5 things about the environment. What's on the walls? What music is playing? What are people eating? Get OUT of your head.

Exercise 4: The Helper

Focus on making the OTHER person comfortable. This shifts your brain from 'Am I okay?' to 'Are THEY okay?' - and reduces self-focus.

ASSERTIVENESS: RETURNING AN ITEM TO A STORE

- Walk in with confidence
- Say: 'I'd like to return this please.'
- If questioned: 'It didn't work for me.'
- You don't need to over-explain or apologize.

Practice notes:

When I tried this: _____

What happened: _____

How I felt before (0-10): ____ After (0-10): ____

What I learned: _____

ASSERTIVENESS: MAKING A PHONE CALL

- Write down key points before calling
- Say: 'Hi, my name is _____. I'm calling about _____.'
- If confused: 'Could you repeat that please?'
- It's okay to pause and think.

Practice notes:

When I tried this: _____

What happened: _____

How I felt before (0-10): _____ After (0-10): _____

What I learned: _____

ASSERTIVENESS: DISAGREEING WITH SOMEONE

- Start with: 'I see it differently...'
- Or: 'I respect your view, and I think...'
- Stay calm. You don't need to 'win.'
- Disagreeing is not rude. Silence is self-betrayal.

Practice notes:

When I tried this: _____

What happened: _____

How I felt before (0-10): ____ After (0-10): ____

What I learned: _____

ASSERTIVENESS: SAYING NO TO AN INVITATION

- Say: 'Thanks for thinking of me. I can't make it.'
- You do NOT need to give a reason.
- If pushed: 'I appreciate it but my answer is no.'
- No is a complete sentence.

Practice notes:

When I tried this: _____

What happened: _____

How I felt before (0-10): ____ After (0-10): ____

What I learned: _____

ASSERTIVENESS: STARTING A CONVERSATION

- Comment on shared environment: 'This place is great.'
- Ask open-ended questions: 'What brings you here?'
- Share something small about yourself.
- Remember: most people love talking about themselves.

Practice notes:

When I tried this: _____

What happened: _____

How I felt before (0-10): ____ After (0-10): ____

What I learned: _____

[illegible]

SELF-COMPASSION EXERCISES

Replace self-criticism with self-compassion:

What I'm criticizing myself for: _____

1. MINDFULNESS (acknowledge without over-identifying):

'This is a moment of suffering. This is hard right now.'

2. COMMON HUMANITY (I'm not alone in this):

'Many people struggle with social anxiety. I'm not the only one.'

3. SELF-KINDNESS (what would I say to a friend?):

WEEKLY PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 1

Week of: _____

Social situations I faced this week:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Safety behaviors I dropped:

Experiments I tried:

Wins/progress (even small):

Overall anxiety this week (0-10): ____

Next week's goal: _____

WEEKLY PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 2

Week of: _____

Social situations I faced this week:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Safety behaviors I dropped:

Experiments I tried:

Wins/progress (even small):

Overall anxiety this week (0-10): ____

Next week's goal: _____

WEEKLY PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 3

Week of: _____

Social situations I faced this week:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Safety behaviors I dropped:

Experiments I tried:

Wins/progress (even small):

Overall anxiety this week (0-10): ____

Next week's goal: _____

WEEKLY PROGRESS TRACKER - Week 4

Week of: _____

Social situations I faced this week:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Safety behaviors I dropped:

Experiments I tried:

Wins/progress (even small):

Overall anxiety this week (0-10): ____

Next week's goal: _____